

Maryland - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG TEN

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Bowl-caliber Power 4 team with a stable quarterback/core and a credible two-win rebound case
Preseason consensus	AP Unranked (0 votes) · SP+ No. 48
Returning production	72% (No. 2) overall · Off. 68% (No. 14) · Def. 75% (No. 4)
Primer power rating	+5.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	6.0 wins · most likely 6-6
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ Better, with the clearest improvement path coming from quarterback continuity and an offense designed to fix the run-game floor
Confidence	Medium-high

2026 identity: Maryland builds around second-year QB Malik Washington, using OC Clint Trickett's run-game structure and Washington's mobility to repair a poor 2025 offense. DC Ted Monachino's defense leans on LB Daniel Wingate and EDGE Sidney Stewart despite secondary turnover and EDGE Zahir Mathis' season-ending injury.

Bottom line: Maryland is more stable than a typical 4-8 rebound candidate and has a realistic bowl path, but the offense still has to prove it can run efficiently and create explosives while the defense replaces high-value secondary production and plays without Mathis.

Beats expectations if: QB Malik Washington makes a second-year efficiency jump, Trickett lifts the No. 124 run game, the new WRs replace departed targets and LB Daniel Wingate/EDGE Sidney Stewart hold the front together.

Disappoints if: The WR rebuild stalls, the run game stays inefficient and the S Jalen Huskey/DB Dontay Joyner/EDGE Zahir Mathis losses expose an already ordinary defense.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB stability:** QB Malik Washington is a settled returning QB1 after 2,963 passing yards and 17 TD as a true freshman.
- 2 Defense:** Maryland returns 72% of production overall (No.2) and 75% on defense (No.4), giving the roster unusual continuity for a 4-8 team.
- 3 Coaching:** OC Clint Trickett is the offensive play-caller and DC Ted Monachino is the defensive play-caller; Aazaar Abdul-Rahim remains co-DC.
- 4 Receiver room:** The WR room is rebuilt after WR Octavian Smith Jr., WR Shaleak Knotts and WR Jalil Farooq left for professional football.
- 5 Defensive front:** EDGE Zahir Mathis is out for the entire 2026 season, making EDGE Zion Elee's expanded role and the front's depth a major swing point.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	4-8 (1-8 Big Ten)	● Poor
Scoring	23.5 PPG	● Below average
Total offense	360.0 YPG	● Below average
Rush offense	104.3 YPG · 4.1 YPC	● Very poor
Pass efficiency	6.25 YPA · 18 TD / 9 INT	● Poor
Third downs	37.2%	● Below average
Scoring defense	26.5 PPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Total defense	402.1 YPG allowed	● Below average
Rush defense	175.6 YPG · 4.4 YPC	● Below average
Pass defense	226.5 YPG · 7.10 YPA · 25 TD allowed	● Average / mixed

Maryland's 4-8 record matched an offense with no reliable conventional strength, particularly in the run game and passing efficiency. The defense was less damaging but still below average overall.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-2.97 · No. 92	● Below average
Off. EPA/play	-0.079 · No. 101	● Below average
Off. success rate	38.3% · No. 115	● Poor
Off. explosive-play rate	9.3% · No. 129	● Very poor
Havoc allowed	15.2% · No. 69	● Average / mixed
Opp.-adjusted defense	-1.74 · No. 80	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.015 · No. 71	● Average / mixed
Def. success rate allowed	43.7% · No. 97	● Below average
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	12.0% · No. 68	● Average / mixed
Havoc created	14.2% · No. 102	● Below average

Advanced-stat read: Maryland’s 2025 problem was structural rather than cosmetic: the offense ranked No.101 in EPA/play, No.115 in success rate and No.129 in explosive-play rate, while the defense was only middling in EPA allowed and poor in success rate/havoc. The 2026 case therefore rests on continuity, Washington’s development and Trickett’s changes producing genuine efficiency gains-not simply regression from a 4-8 record.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Michael Locksley - returning	● ↔ Program/QB-development continuity lowers transition risk
OC/QB / play-caller	◆ Clint Trickett - from Jacksonville State OC	● ↑ New run-game ideas directly target the 2025 offensive weakness
DC/OLB / play-caller	Ted Monachino - returning	● ↔ Staff continuity supports a defense with strong returning production

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ WR Chris Durr Jr.	Wyoming	● ↔ 45-469-4 in 2025 gives Maryland a credible immediate major-role receiver.
◆ WR Na'eem Abdul-Rahim Gladding	Old Dominion	● ↔ 51-667-6 in 2025 supplies proven volume to a room replacing three veteran departures to professional football.
◆ WR Ejani Shakir	Independence CC	● ↔ Incoming addition with 43-724-6 receiving and 397 return yards; useful upside with junior-college projection risk.
◆ RB Harry Dalton III	USC	● ↔ Adds major-rotation competition behind/with RB DeJuan Williams in a run game that must improve.

Out	To	Loss
WR Octavian Smith Jr.	NFL (Baltimore), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Veteran receiver loss from a room already requiring a target redistribution.
WR Shaleak Knotts	NFL (Minnesota), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Receiver turnover continues; his later waiver does not change that he left for the NFL.
WR Jalil Farooq	Minnesota Vikings rookie minicamp	● ↓ Another veteran target departs; his NFL opportunity was a rookie-minicamp tryout, not a confirmed NFL roster spot.
OL Alan Herron	NFL (New Orleans), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Material veteran offensive-line loss.
OL Aliou Bah	LSU	● ↔ Additional offensive-line turnover, partly offset by returning C Michael Hershey and incoming competition.

Offensive net: ● ↔ Roughly similar composition with a higher developmental ceiling at QB/run design but major receiver replacement work

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DB Jordan Scruggs	West Virginia	● ↔ Current Maryland addition who gives the secondary experienced competition after major departures.
◆ DB Amari Jackson	Boston College	● ↔ Adds Power 4 secondary competition but does not fully erase Huskey/Joyner turnover.
◆ DL Armon Parker	Washington	● ↔ Provides defensive-line depth to a front dealing with the Mathis injury and prior turnover.
◆ DL Jayvon Parker	Washington	● ↔ Brings another veteran body to the defensive-line rotation.

Out	To	Loss
S Jalen Huskey	NFL (Jacksonville), Round 3, No. 100	● ↓ Third-round safety loss after 11 starts, 72 tackles and four interceptions.
DB Dontay Joyner	-	● ↓ Coach-confirmed non-return removes another material 2025 defensive back with no destination listed.
DB Braydon Lee	Arkansas	● ↔ Adds to secondary churn, though current transfers and returning veterans provide replacement options.
DB La'khi Roland	Arkansas	● ↔ Additional defensive-back turnover in a unit already replacing Huskey and Joyner.
DL Dillan Fontus	Syracuse	● ↔ Front-depth loss partly offset by multiple incoming linemen.

Defensive net: ● ↓ Similar-to-slightly worse composition; high returning production is real.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Trickett-led attack built around QB Malik Washington's mobility, new run concepts and a rebuilt WR group.	A settled QB1, C Michael Hershey, productive transfer WRs and RB DeJuan Williams provide a workable core.	The 2025 offense was poor in rushing, success rate and explosiveness, so the changes must produce real efficiency gains.
Defense	Monachino defense centered on LB Daniel Wingate and EDGE Sidney Stewart with new depth around them.	Strong returning production and veteran staff continuity support the floor.	S Jalen Huskey/DB Dontay Joyner are gone, EDGE Zahir Mathis is out and 2025 efficiency was already ordinary.
Special teams	Stable returning specialists.	Both primary specialists carry national watchlist recognition, and SP+ rates the unit No. 39.	The profile supports stability more than an elite projection.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B	● ↑	High	QB Malik Washington returns as the settled starter after a productive true-freshman season.
RB	● B-	● ↑	Medium-high	RB DeJuan Williams gives the new offense a credible lead-back candidate and improvement path.
WR	● B-	● ↔	Medium	Productive transfer additions replace departed volume, but the new hierarchy still must settle.
TE	● B-	● ↔	Medium-high	TE Dorian Fleming provides one of the steadier returning pass-game roles.
OL	● C+	● ↔	Medium	C Michael Hershey anchors a line that still needs better rushing efficiency and full-role stability.
DL/Edge	● B-	● ↔	Medium-low	Returning edge pieces remain useful, but the unit must absorb a major injury and personnel turnover.
LB	● B	● ↔	High	LB Daniel Wingate gives Maryland a high-confidence defensive centerpiece.
Secondary	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	Major departures and new roles make the back end the defense's largest uncertainty.
Special teams	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	Both primary specialists return with national watchlist recognition.
Coaching	● B	● ↑	Medium-high	HC Michael Locksley remains while OC Clint Trickett adds a new run-game structure and play-calling voice.
Overall	● B-	● ↑	Medium-high	High returning production and a settled QB support improvement, but 2025 efficiency and secondary churn cap the grade.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 22, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Malik Washington	QB	● Solid Power 4 starter with meaningful second-year upside	-	Returns as the settled QB1 after 2,963 passing yards and 17 TD as a true freshman; the entire rebound case is easier if he becomes more efficient.
Daniel Wingate	LB	● High-end conference starter	Bednarik · Butkus	Returns after 102 tackles as the most stable defensive centerpiece.
Michael Hershey	C	● Solid Power 4 line anchor	Rimington	Started all 12 games at center and provides rare continuity for an offense trying to rebuild its rushing efficiency.
DeJuan Williams	RB	● Power 4 lead-back projection	Doak Walker	Returns as the lead-role candidate in the unit Trickett most needs to improve from 2025.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Dorian Fleming	TE	● Solid Power 4 starter projection	John Mackey	One of the more stable returning pass-game pieces while the receiver room turns over.
◆ Chris Durr Jr. (TR: Wyoming)	WR	● Major-role transfer with projection risk	-	His 45 catches, 469 yards and four TD make him one of the best-supported candidates to absorb departed WR volume.
Sidney Stewart	EDGE	● Solid Power 4 returning edge anchor	-	The defense needs his continuity more after Mathis was lost for the season.
Zion Elee	EDGE	● High-upside expanded-role defender	-	Mathis' injury materially increases Elee's expected workload, making his readiness a direct determinant of the pass-rush floor.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	A top-third schedule for a bowl-line team: the first month offers a path to bank wins, but Ohio State plus a late USC/Penn State finish sharply limits the margin for error.
Difficulty	● 7/10 · Difficult · SP+ SOS No. 30
Hardest stretch	Illinois -> at Purdue -> Wisconsin -> at USC -> Penn State
Swing games	Virginia Tech, UCLA, at Nebraska, Rutgers, Illinois, at Purdue, Wisconsin
Advantage	Hampton and UConn precede the Big Ten grind, Maryland gets several bowl-relevant peers at home, and the bye comes before Illinois.
Expected	6.0 wins · most likely 6-6
Floor / ceiling	4-8 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	The strongest pro-Maryland signal is unusually high returning production around a settled young QB.
Back them when	As a short underdog or modest favorite against teams that cannot punish the rebuilt secondary, especially if the Washington/Trickett run game is showing clear early-down improvement.
Fade/pass when	Against elite pass rushes or explosive passing teams until the OL, edge replacement and secondary rotations demonstrate stability.
Key monitor	run-game efficiency, WR target distribution, EDGE Zion Elee workload, DB Jordan Scruggs/DB Amari Jackson roles, late-camp availability
Week 1 baseline	vs. Hampton: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Maryland –45.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Maryland has unusual continuity for a 4-8 team, led by QB Malik Washington and a defense returning most of its production. OC Clint Trickett’s run-game redesign gives the offense a concrete route to improve its weakest area.

The bowl case is credible, but not automatic: the rebuilt WR room must create more explosives, while the defense must absorb major secondary losses and EDGE Zahir Mathis’ injury. Six wins remains the sound center.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [fall camp](#) · [transfers](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [position/camp update](#) · [Jordan Scruggs 2026 roster bio](#) · [Wide Receiver Eiani Shakir Joins](#)

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